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Flying the flag: gender and national identity in English newspapers during the 2006 World Cup

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This essay analyses selected English newspapers' gendered narratives about the English soccer team's star player, Wayne Rooney, and the captain, David Beckham. Narratives are compared with those devoted to Rooney's fiancée, Coleen McLoughlin, and Beckham's wife, Victoria, who with other players' wives and girlfriends (WAGS) travelled to Germany to support England during the 2006 World Cup. It uses textual analysis to examine how the newspapers' gendered narratives intersected with nationalistic discourses. Theoretical insight is drawn from Connell's theory of gender power relations. Narratives about Rooney emphasize his northern working-class roots in the construction of his hegemonic hypermasculinity and role as a 'patriot at play,' while narratives about McLoughlin illustrate her subordinate role. More fluid and contradictory narratives are reserved for Beckham, who is known for his more androgynous image, and his wife Victoria, whose strong influence over 'the skipper' challenged the traditional gender order.

Introduction

This study draws on Connell's theory of gender power relations¹ in analysing selected English newspapers' narratives about the English national soccer team captain, David Beckham, and one of England's best players, Wayne Rooney. The gendered narratives about Beckham and Rooney were compared with those devoted to their partners Victoria Beckham and Coleen McLoughlin, respectively, as well as other England players' wives and girlfriends (WAGS) during the 2006 soccer World Cup. English newspapers' coverage of the 2006 World Cup circulates (re)presentations of masculinity and femininity globally, particularly through their online versions, and thus they play an important role shaping the contemporary gender order. Therefore, English newspaper narratives about selected English footballers and their wives and girlfriends during the 2006 World Cup provide an ideal means to examine how gendered and national identity are constructed, (re)produced, and contested.

During the World Cup the symbolism of the performances of the English national football team is seen as a potent signifier of masculinity and a barometer of the health of the nation. Reflecting this, Tuck described how journalists reporting on the fortunes of the national team during a major international sporting

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tournament perform the role of 'media patriots', skilfully employing narratives to engender a collective sense of support for the national team.² Maguire and Poulton noted how during major international soccer tournaments male soccer players become 'embodiments of nations' and 'patriots at play' in mediated accounts.³ Thus the gendered identity of the England players undoubtedly intersects with their national character. However, gendered identity, like other social constructions, is fluid and the World Cup is a setting in which agencies are in play, especially the agency of the players and their wives and girlfriends in (re)constructing and contesting dominant gender ideology.

Professional men's soccer is the world's most popular spectator sport, and in soccer-crazed England, the 2006 World Cup took on even greater importance when many English soccer fans had cause to believe that their country fielded its best opportunity to win its second Jules Rimet trophy and the nation's first since the historic victory of the 1966 squad. International sport is also an important form of entertainment in today's popular culture, in no small part due to burgeoning digital media coverage and global appeal of celebrity athletes.⁴ The contemporary trend of the 'dumbing down' or tabloidization of newspapers has resulted in the invasion of sport stars' private lives by paparazzi and the demystification of celebrity sport stars.⁵ England's deep run in the 2006 World Cup and the build-up to the tournament were primary foci and news sources for daily newspapers. Not surprisingly, considering the demand for any news on the World Cup and the downtime between England's matches, the extensive newspaper coverage often veered away from the field. Multiple articles largely focused on the English players' personal lives, and in particular on the lifestyles of the English players' WAGs, who were supporting their men in Germany. As Turner noted, in an era of celebrity culture sports and entertainment stars' private lives often receive more media coverage than their professional achievements.⁶

A plethora of research has contrasted coverage of female and male athletes, with many scholars arguing sports media predominately uphold traditional masculine and feminine stereotypes, placing male athletes and men's sport well above female athletes and women's sport in the gender order.⁷ Thus it is now generally assumed that sport and media assist in the maintenance of hegemonic masculinity in society.⁸ However, few studies have directly compared male athletes to non-athletic women receiving extensive coverage in the same media content. When the English Football Association (FA) broke with previous English World Cup tradition, and allowed the English players' wives and girlfriends to travel to Germany to support their men in the 2006 World Cup, it provided the perfect opportunity to compare the gendered narratives and how they intersected with English national identity.

Multiple studies on newspaper sport coverage have consistently shown male athletes receive far more coverage than female athletes in most sports.⁹ The primary exceptions were that women generally receive more or at least equitable amounts of coverage as men in sports socially and historically construed as feminine or gender-neutral, such as figure skating, gymnastics, swimming and tennis.¹⁰ Regardless of the amount of coverage provided, numerous quantitative and qualitative studies have shown female athletes in newspaper narratives frequently have their skill level and athleticism compared unfavourably with male athletes and their accomplishments trivialized, and are often described as sex objects, with the media delving into their physical appearances and attire, and noting their heterosexual husbands or boyfriends to reinforce the female athletes' heterosexuality.¹¹

However, most research on gender in sports media content has directly compared coverage of female and male athletes, often only casually noting references within the content to men or women who were deemed newsworthy for these sports stories even though they were not competing. The lack of comparisons between sporting individuals of one sex and narratives of the opposite sex who were not competitive athletes is primarily because media generally focus their coverage on the sporting participants. However, English popular newspaper coverage of the 2006 World Cup was so exhaustive that it did not follow the traditional script, in large part due to sensationalistic articles on the English soccer players' WAGS.

Theoretical framework

Gendered identity

Connell's contemporary theory of gender power relations¹² rearticulates Gramsci's theory of hegemony in class relations.¹³ Connell's theory is a relational model of gender, based on the notion that there are multiple femininities and masculinities operating in a hierarchy of socially constructed power relations.¹⁴ Connell noted masculinities are configurations of social practice within gender relations,¹⁵ which are formed by both individual character and personality, but also by institutions, economic relations and opportunity, relationships and sexuality. Although recognizing masculinities vary within social context, Connell claimed that the most idealized form of masculinity in the gendered hierarchy is hegemonic masculinity, which reinforces heterosexuality, aggression and assertiveness.¹⁶ Competitive sport, with its emphasis on competition and hierarchy, is frequently defined in a language of hegemonic masculinity and provides an ideal cultural setting for hegemonic masculinity to be (re)constructed.¹⁷ From childhood through adulthood, boys and men are socialized to partake in sport, which is used to sculpt bodies and construct masculine identities, both of which align with dominant perspectives of hegemonic masculinity. Hegemonic masculinity is normally represented by socially elite, white, Western, heterosexual, able-bodied males, which associates it with great social prestige.¹⁸ Through a complex system of negotiated socially constructed power relations, hegemonic masculinity subordinates and marginalizes other masculinities and femininities. However, it should be noted, 'a degree of overlap or blurring between hegemonic and complicit masculinities is extremely likely if hegemony is effective'.¹⁹

Gender is relational, and socially constructed masculinities are defined in relation to femininity. According to Connell, there is no hegemonic femininity but an 'emphasized femininity' that is associated with able-bodied socially elite, white, heterosexual, feminine women who conform with the socially constructed gender power relations by accommodating rather than challenging hegemonic masculinity.²⁰ Although hegemonic masculinity is socially constructed and is perpetually being challenged, reinforced and reconstructed in relation to other forms of masculinities and femininities, the characteristics of hegemonic masculinity are frequently reinscribed as 'natural' and 'self-evident'. One area where characteristics of hegemonic masculinity are often portrayed is through the mainstream media.²¹

Methodology

Textual analysis

We utilized textual analysis, an unobtrusive and non-reactive tool that reveals both subtle and explicit meanings in media content.²² We compared how gender and national identity were constructed about the captain and the star player with their respective partners during the 2006 World Cup in five English national newspapers. Through our methodology we employed multiple levels of inductive coding merged with larger theoretical conceptualizations of gender identity. The specific texts, methods, and analysis are explained in the appendix.

Results

Analyses of the newspapers' gendered and nationalistic narratives revealed exhaustive coverage of David Beckham and Rooney. The following sections outline the dominant themes found in the selected English newspaper's narratives about the gendered and national identity of Beckham and Rooney – generally recognized as England's highest-profile players. These narratives are compared with the mediated accounts about Beckham's wife Victoria and Rooney's fiancée, Coleen McLoughlin, as well as other England players' WAGS during the 2006 World Cup.

During the 2006 World Cup the England national soccer team was front-page news on a daily basis in all five examined newspapers. Each newspaper issued a rally cry of sorts to its readers, seemingly to generate interest and galvanize support for their masculine heroes and 'patriots at play'. The newspapers did this by drawing on a shared, collective English national identity, in which readers were urged to all get behind 'our' boys representing 'En-ger-land'.

Wayne Rooney

'England's divine saviour'

The England soccer team qualified for the World Cup finals held in Germany in 2006 with a team dubbed the 'golden generation' because it was perceived to be the best group of players representing England since the 1966 World Cup winners. Accordingly, the England team was expected to match or better their quarter-final finishes in their last two World Cup tournaments. Rooney was injured before the World Cup. With the assumption that he could recover from his metatarsal injury, the 21-year-old Rooney was depicted as the potential saviour, a player who blended the traditional English masculine qualities of honest endeavour, commitment and aggression with youthful enthusiasm, a sublime touch and inventive technical skill. Rooney's much-anticipated return from injury was greeted with the headline: 'It's Just Great to Have the Wonderkid Back'.²³

Cometh the hour, cometh the man-child

In a contradictory narrative that drew on elements of Rooney's new-laddism type of hedonistic masculinity but also his youth and suspect temperament, Ian Ridley likened Rooney to England's greatest player from the previous generation, Paul 'Gazza' Gascoigne, who became famous as a young player for performing admirably in his only World Cup final tournament. Gascoigne, however, also

became known for becoming overwhelmed with emotion and crying after England's loss in a penalty shoot-out against West Germany in the semifinal of the 1990 World Cup as well as his off-the-field, alcohol-fuelled misdemeanours. Thus references to Gascoigne also evoke notions of a self-destructive version of masculinity and new laddism, which reasserts 'elements of traditional young male working-class culture'.²⁴ In describing Rooney's desperation to play after recovering from injury, Ridley described Rooney as 'A man-child who just wants to be given the ball'.²⁵

'Desperate Dan'

Class undoubtedly contributed to the construction of Rooney's masculinity. Narratives about Rooney, who grew up in Croxteth, a working-class area of Liverpool, were anchored in the hypermasculine ethos of his northern working-class roots. The stocky Rooney's masculinity seemed designed to evoke memories of the traditional blue-collar English footballer from a bygone era. Messner noted that the performance of hypermasculinity by class-subordinated men is a common coping strategy constructed by them to provide a sense of power, at least symbolically, in a context in which their power and social mobility are usually limited.²⁶ Columnist Jeff Powell described Rooney's frustration watching England's first game against Paraguay from the bench thus: 'With his lantern jaw sprouting a growth of stubble which was more bricklayer than designer, Wayne Rooney looked like Desperate Dan.'²⁷ Desperate Dan is an iconic fictional character in the British children's comic, *The Dandy*. Known to most baby-boomer-era English schoolboys, Desperate Dan is a cowboy famous for his strength, toughness and invulnerability, but also his stupidity. The reference to Desperate Dan seems to set Rooney apart as a kind of anachronism, nostalgically positioning him as a kind of masculine throwback to a previous era in which working-class footballers stereotypically conformed with hypermasculine virtues. It also noticeably draws on the mind-body dualism stereotype about working class athletes.

'The blood-soaked warrior'

Sporting heroes are frequently revered as examples of hegemonic masculinity and as 'patriots at play' through commercial promotion. Although the benefits of the 'patriarchal dividend' include social mobility as well as financial riches in the form of sponsorship and endorsement contracts, living up to the strenuous demands of hegemonic masculinity comes at a cost, too.²⁸ For example, as Messner noted, hegemonic masculine team sporting cultures require sport stars such as Rooney to play before they have fully healed from serious injury.²⁹ At the outset of the World Cup, as the potential fulcrum of England's attack, Rooney carried the hopes of a demanding nation on his young shoulders, even though it was not known whether he had fully recovered from a serious metatarsal injury.

Prior to Rooney's comeback game, he was featured in a Nike promotional photograph that was shown in most of the newspapers examined, as well as on a 60-foot-high billboard on the M4 in West London. Because Adidas was the official sponsor of the 2006 World Cup, Nike was unable to advertise within any of the World Cup stadia and therefore promoted its brand through creative ambush marketing strategies. The poster of Rooney above the caption 'Just Do It' revealed Rooney in an aggressive pose. From the waist up Rooney had the Cross of St.

George painted on him with the wet red paint resembling blood. His arms were horizontally outstretched, his fists clenched, and his painted face contorted as though he was screaming. Nike claimed the promotional photograph showed him in his trademark goal-scoring celebration pose. On the front page of the sports section, the *Daily Mail* set the poster against the headline 'Shock tactics. I've picked Wayne because he terrifies Sweden, says Sven'.³⁰ This appeared to reinforce both Rooney's status as a 'patriot at play' and his warrior-like hegemonic hypermasculinity. However, as it was undoubtedly intended to do, the hypermasculine display in the poster was the subject of contradictory discussion, much of it pejorative in tone. In the centre pages of the *Daily Mail*, author Stephen Glover opined that the poster could be interpreted 'as a battle cry from the dark ages or a throwback to the Crusades', while also suggesting that given the recent 'outbreaks of violence involving England's army of fans' the poster depicting Rooney 'as a blood-soaked warrior-God ready to smite our opponents' was in bad taste. Glover also noted the obvious sacrilegious element describing it as an 'echo ... surely deliberate, of Christ's crucifixion'.³¹ Although highly critical of Nike, Glover concluded:

Rooney, of course, is more sinned against than sinning. The one-time frequenter of Merseyside prostitutes is hardly an obvious candidate for divine celebration, though admittedly St Augustine passed a misspent youth. Nike has exploited him almost as blatantly as it is alleged to exploit its labourers in the Third World who make its costly footwear.³²

This narrative illustrates how Rooney's youth and class were evoked to create a disempowering discourse about Nike's capitalist exploitation. Glover neglected to articulate how media conglomerates also sought to profit from the World Cup by reporting about Nike's poster. The reference to his use of prostitutes, widely reported in several red-top (tabloid) newspapers in 2004, also situated Rooney as a throwback to the 'men behaving badly' new-laddism, hedonistic masculine culture of the 1990s, which embraced 'having a laugh,' alcohol consumption and objectifying women.³³

'War minus the shooting'

Garland and Rowe noted that during major international football tournaments such as the World Cup, journalists seem to embrace George Orwell's characterization of sport as 'war minus the shooting' by frequently drawing on military references to dramatize their accounts.³⁴ Military references, which reinforced Rooney's hegemonic hypermasculinity as a 'patriot at play,' resonated throughout the narratives. Typifying this, Rooney was featured in a photograph on the front page of the *Daily Mail* wearing an England shirt, with the Cross of St. George in the background, pointing his right index finger, above the headline, 'Your country needs YOU at 4 pm today'.³⁵ This photograph was carefully choreographed to duplicate the most famous First World War British army recruiting poster, which featured Lord Kitchener, the Secretary of State for War, rallying the country with a call to arms. However, Rooney's immaturity and undisciplined temperament were revealed when he was sent off in England's quarter-final match against Portugal. Columnist Henry Winter contrasted Rooney's masculine performance unfavourably with the young men who fought and died for their country during the First World War:

England's support so adore the combative Rooney that he will be forgiven, although one member of the official Football Association supporters' club observed yesterday: 'Rooney is young, but you can't help thinking of the thousands of youngsters that died 90 years ago, on the same day fighting for their country at the Somme'. Rooney's idea of fighting for his country cost England dear.³⁶

This pejorative but false comparison of Rooney's performance of masculine aggression with the nation's traditional heroes, the British soldiers who lost their lives fighting for their country, provides an illustration of how references to traditional masculine heroes are woven into narratives about iconic sport stars or celebrities in popular culture. It further illustrates how Rooney's masculine identity intersected with his national identity as a 'patriot at play', and provides an example of how media accounts draw on selective traditions and nostalgia from popular memory to provide context in a way intended to appeal to readers, in this case linking the World Cup with the Battle of the Somme.

Ronaldo—'the nancy boy'

In an era of red-top, celebrity-driven journalism in which the pressure to increase circulation seems to produce more controversial narratives, a 'build-them-up-then-knock-them-down cycle' permeates popular newspaper narratives.³⁷ Masculine images that conform to hegemonic masculinity and reify the hierarchical gender order are generally celebrated, whereas those that transgress the accepted notions of hegemonic masculinity with new configurations of masculinity are often the subject of pejorative discourses. England's elimination from the 2006 World Cup at the quarter-final stage led to inevitable recriminations. However, Rooney, who was sent off for stamping on the groin of Ricardo Carvalho, a Portuguese player, was not subjected to the same media vilification that Beckham endured in the aftermath of England's elimination from the 1998 World Cup after he was sent off for a similar retaliation offence. It seemed that the public and media scorn of Beckham was magnified because of his failure to conform to the traditional hegemonic masculinity associated with professional footballers. In comparison, Rooney was forgiven fairly quickly for his act of aggression. Instead, xenophobic narratives about Portuguese player Cristiano Ronaldo muted the criticism of Rooney's indiscipline. Ronaldo, who ironically was also Rooney's Manchester United club teammate, appeared to inflame the situation after Rooney stamped on his Portuguese teammate Carvalho by vehemently protesting to the referee. Television showed Ronaldo winking to the Portuguese bench after Rooney was sent off. Predictably, the English newspaper narratives drew on negative ethnic stereotypes and slurs about Latino football players when describing Ronaldo's poor sportsmanship. *The Sun* also suggested that Ronaldo, whose relationships with various female models had previously received exhaustive coverage, was a 'nancy boy', an English colloquialism for an effeminate or homosexual man. This homophobic slur, associating Ronaldo with effeminacy, clearly illustrated how the gendered narratives intersected with the national identity of Ronaldo and reified the traditional hierarchical gender order.

David Beckham

As a world-class soccer player, Beckham was known for his ability to deliver pinpoint crosses, strike penetrating, diagonal, long passes and bend his signature free

kicks around and over defensive walls.³⁸ However, Beckham transcends the sport of soccer in a way no other soccer player ever has. He is one the world's most recognized celebrity athletes and is known for his contradictory, fluid brand of masculinity that challenges the working-class, conservative, hegemonic new laddism typically associated with English professional footballers. This form of masculine culture associated with English footballers equates any hint of effeminacy with homosexuality and strictly enforces the traditional gender boundaries that Beckham appears to flout.³⁹ Beckham's keen interest in high fashion, his androgynous taste in clothes and his professed 'metrosexuality' also contradict the accepted conventions of the traditionally conservative hegemonic masculine English football culture.⁴⁰

'Captain Fantastic'

Smart suggested that sport stars gain authenticity through their athletic performances and this is what separates them from other celebrities.⁴¹ However, Beckham's authenticity as a world-class football player and by implication his hegemonic masculinity was questioned prior to the 2006 World Cup, with some journalists suggesting that his global celebrity status had outstripped his sporting accomplishments. This theme resonated throughout the course of the World Cup. However, Beckham's goals and assists in the early matches of the tournament seemed to re-affirm his athletic, masculine authenticity and status as a world-class player, at least temporarily. He was praised for the vital goals he scored from his trademark free kicks, which proved to be the difference between England qualifying and being eliminated. Typifying the type of narrative found, a *Daily Mirror* editorial noted how 'Millions watching on TV cheered wildly as Captain Fantastic David Beckham's stunning free-kick secured the 1–0 win over Ecuador'.⁴² When Beckham delivered on his promise by scoring the winning goal against Ecuador, despite not feeling well and vomiting on the pitch moments after scoring, columnist Henry Winter typified the general tone of the narratives by describing how 'Beckham's sixty minute strike was one of those redemption moments in which he specializes, evoking memories of his Sapporo penalty against France '98 nemesis, Argentina. Cometh the hour here, cometh the man.'⁴³

Beckham, however, was also the subject of many contradictory narratives in the newspapers examined. He was singled out for criticism for England's eventual failure to recapture the glory of the World Cup-winning team of 1966. Boorstin's social commentary⁴⁴ over four decades ago, that public image had become more important than achievement or substance, resonated in the newspaper narratives about Beckham, whose mediated celebrity appeal seemed to have overtaken his football prowess. Sportswriter Jeff Powell opined: 'The quality of leadership does not appear to be as fully formed in David Beckham's consciousness as his sense of celebrity.'⁴⁵

Who wears the trousers?

Beckham's athleticism, race, heterosexuality and good looks all conform to accepted notions of hegemonic masculinity and thus provide him with a platform for cultural hegemony and privilege. However, his wife Victoria, better known as 'Posh Spice' from the popular female pop group the Spice Girls, is widely reported to be the dominant partner both in their marriage and in shaping his off-the-field career.⁴⁶

Beckham has also been presented as a puppet of pop-music impresario Simon Fuller's management agency, which has carefully cultivated and honed his new-age man image for public consumption and commodification. Several narratives suggested that Beckham's influence on manager Sven-Göran Eriksson during the 2006 World Cup was overbearing and unhealthy. The newspaper narratives suggested Beckham was heavily involved in the decision to allow the WAGS to invade the traditionally masculine space of the team camp at the World Cup by being allowed to accompany their men in Germany, but not before consulting with his domineering wife Victoria. Expressing concern that the WAGS could be an unwelcome distraction, columnist Jeff Powell articulated how 'the folks back home are entitled to wonder how absolutely these young men are concentrated on and dedicated to the task of bringing home the most patriotic prize in sport'.⁴⁷ The theme of Victoria's influence over Beckham was evident in some of the narratives about Beckham's decision to resign as England's captain in the aftermath of the quarter-final defeat by Portugal. Under the headline, 'POSH HELPED SKIPPER QUIT', author Nick Parker reported how 'David Beckham decided to step down as England captain yesterday after an emotional heart-to-heart phone call from wife Victoria'.⁴⁸

The changing face of masculinity – crying for England

The national soccer team is central to both national and masculine identity in England. It has traditionally been associated with an ethos of high physical work rate, honest endeavour, commitment and the notion of fair play.⁴⁹ Beckham and his teammates' English masculinity was the subject of media criticism for their apparent lack of work rate and inability to deal with the German summer heat. In particular, poor performances by Beckham were dissected and compared unfavourably with those of England's 1966 World Cup-winning captain, Bobby Moore. Patrick Barclay complained about the players' lack of fitness and conditioning, and questioned their masculine fortitude, comparing them unfavourably to the heroes of England's only team to win the World Cup:

Those of us who remain of the opinion that he can supervise a triumph in this tournament are having our faith vigorously shaken both by his apparently inept team building and the players' condition; it was awful to see them desperately swigging after only a few minutes, like pub-team players wilting under their hangovers on a Sunday morning. Forty years ago, Alf Ramsey told his men to stand up after 90 minutes lest the equally tired West Germans think them vulnerable. And, of course, they did, before their leonine march culminated in Bobby Moore's brandishing of the Jules Rimet Trophy. I sometimes think the current lot should wear three mice on their shirts.⁵⁰

In hegemonic masculine cultures found in team sports men have traditionally been expected to demonstrate mental toughness and resilience. Any hint of vulnerability is equated with weakness and thus male athletes have traditionally been constrained in the emotions they can express.⁵¹ Drawing on this theme, the newspaper narratives appeared to question the English players' hegemonic masculinity after the English players' and managers' emotional and tearful reaction to their penalty shoot-out loss against Portugal. Columnist Jeff Powell seemed to suggest that in the new millennium it has become more socially acceptable for elite sportsmen to show emotion and cry, but only if it was for their country and not

for themselves: 'The most disgracefully prepared team in England's World Cup history was ... captained by [David Beckham] a narcissist so obsessed with himself that when the inevitable humiliation came he cried for himself, not for his country.'⁵²

This illustrates how Beckham's non-compliance with accepted conventions of the traditionally conservative English football culture was criticized – e.g., his perceived narcissism. Tim Rich's narrative noted how the victorious England captain of the 1966 team, Moore, and his teammate, ball-winning midfielder Nobby Styles, 'would never shed tears', but Rich also acknowledged the shift in accepted notions of masculinity, concluding that 'Beckham is a symbol of his age, a less certain, less austere age perhaps, but one in which boys cry'.⁵³ These narratives about Beckham crying seem to engage in what Connell described as a form of 'historical thinking' or 'consciousness' in relation to masculinity in which the 'social transformations' are compared with the past and reluctantly or grudgingly accepted.⁵⁴ However, this 'historical consciousness' is also often used in contemporary masculinity politics by popular conservative commentators to advocate the position that masculinity is in crisis.⁵⁵

Coleen McLoughlin and Victoria Beckham

Space invaders

During previous World Cup tournaments the English players were not accompanied by their wives, girlfriends and families because previous managers wanted their 'patriots at play' to focus on winning the tournament without domestic distractions. However, for the 2006 World Cup, the WAGS of the England team travelled to Germany to spend time with their partners. Their invasion of a formerly masculine space predictably drew criticism from some quarters. After languid performances in England's early-round matches against mediocre opposition, journalist Stephen Glover questioned this change: '[W]hat good the presence of the sybaritic young women in Germany is doing to members of the England team, who are being permitted several trysts by Sven-Göran Eriksson. Some of the energy expended during these encounters with WAGS might have been better spent on the pitch.'⁵⁶ Writer Tom Bryant quoted former England manager, Sir Bobby Robson, opining "'We're going to war. You can't fight a war worrying about your wife or child. For one month, kiss them goodbye".'⁵⁷ These sentiments typified the type of narrative directed at the young women invading a traditionally masculine space. They also illustrate how hegemonic masculinity was constructed in the socio-historical context of the 2006 World Cup.

The WAGS' presence in Germany, particularly Victoria Beckham and McLoughlin, seemed to reinforce the heteromale social capital of the England players. Drawing on this theme, columnist Suzanne Moore suggested 'WAGS are programmed for three activities: sex, sunbathing and shopping. Each needs an entourage of tan therapists, pedicurists, and fluffers' so they can look good for their men.⁵⁸ Victoria Beckham's and McLoughlin's presence to support their partners also provided the popular newspapers with the celebrity couples they seem to crave. The coverage seemed to reflect an insatiable desire to know more about the private lives of celebrities.

'Known for being known'

On the back of the popular fictional television show *Footballers' Wives*, which depicted the opulent lifestyle of soccer players' wives and girlfriends, the newspapers devoted a gratuitous amount of coverage to McLoughlin, Victoria Beckham and all the WAGS during the 2006 World Cup. In the 'celebrity obsessed culture' of professional soccer in the new millennium the WAGS, whose celebrity status, with the exception of Victoria Beckham, was only based on their relationship with one of the English soccer players, became in the Boorstin sense 'known for being known'.⁵⁹ Through exhaustive mass media attention, McLoughlin and the other WAGS seemed destined to become B-list celebrities, or people who achieve their transient '15 minutes of fame' in an era of pervasive celebrity culture. As journalists Natalie Clark and James Mills opined, 'Being photographed is a key objective of most WAGS'.⁶⁰ Sportswriter Ian Wooldridge commented: 'No one would have the faintest idea who they were if they weren't married to or partnered by a footballer'.⁶¹ The format of the World Cup provided the teams with several days of rest between games. The journalists, particularly those working for the red-tops, filled the void between the matches with voyeuristic accounts of the WAGS' activities. McLoughlin and other WAGS were the darlings of the paparazzi. Their primary purpose seemed to be to feed the desire for new celebrity figures.⁶² In this sense, they were media creations. The newspapers made them and unmade them through either over-exposure or their disappearance from the tabloid limelight.⁶³ The coverage of the WAGS was replete with photographs of their hyper feminine, glamorous, scantily-clad and sexy appearances for their readers' gaze and light entertainment. Typifying this type of narrative, journalist Clare Raymond opined: 'Once again Victoria Beckham captured everyone's attention as she turned up in the tiniest white hot-pants'.⁶⁴ The newspaper coverage of McLoughlin and Victoria Beckham seemed to epitomize the passive role of women throughout the ages. They performed the roles of the decorative or attractive, objectified, sexualized and subordinate female admirers and supporters of their men and their masculine sport performance. Much of the newspapers' narratives about McLoughlin and Victoria Beckham seemed designed to capture their emphasized femininity and secondary role. The newspapers' titillating headlines and salacious narratives were replete with double entendres – like how they displayed fine form, in contrast to their husbands' poor displays on the field. Typifying this type of narrative about Victoria Beckham celebrating an England goal, writer Giles Smith suggested that 'Victoria's bouncing celebration showed Sven what he was missing-a perky pair of strikers'.⁶⁵ This type of sexual objectification served to reinforce dominant gender ideology.

'Girls behaving badly'

In the 1990s, new-lad culture inspired 'laddettes', or young women who adopt the similar hedonistic lifestyles. The 'girls behaving badly', inebriated, profligate shopping habits, fake tans, narcissistic desire for media and grooming habits of McLoughlin and some of the other younger WAGS seemed to conform with this and were roundly ridiculed in the newspaper narratives. Under the headline 'The 4am Girls!: England stars' wives and pals in champagne party till dawn', columnist Jeremy Armstrong noted how 'Giggly Coleen McLoughlin became England's unofficial cheerleader as she led the WAGS in a boozy sing-song on a seven-hour bender'.⁶⁶ The WAGS' fake tans were also the subject of much newspaper

coverage. With a reputation built on sashaying around the hotel grounds and swimming pool during the day and partying at night, the rules in the era of celebrity culture seemed to reward their misbehaviour with more coverage. Thus the newspapers' coverage of the WAGS seemed to reflect the notion that there was no such thing as bad publicity, as long as their voyeuristically salacious accounts of girls behaving badly sold more copies.

'Victoria Beckham – the queen bee'

Narratives about Victoria Beckham were among the few that challenged and contradicted the dominant gender ideology. As a member of the Spice Girls, Victoria Beckham was more famous and wealthy than her husband David Beckham when they met. The Spice Girls were also known for 'girl power', a form of feminism that embraced both feminine appearances and gender equality, which challenges traditional patriarchy. Indeed there has been a suggestion that Victoria is the dominant partner in the Beckhams' marriage.⁶⁷ However, a disempowering theme throughout the tournament was how the journalists compared McLoughlin and Victoria Beckham in attempts to decide who won in the 'emphasized femininity' stakes in terms of fashion, publicity and patriotism. At the outset of the World Cup, journalists Natalie Clark and James Mills reported: 'The women are here for the most important competition in the world – To decide which is "Queen of the Wives". Victoria Beckham holds the title. But she is keenly aware that Miss McLoughlin is after her crown.'⁶⁸ This media-generated rivalry noted 'Posh puts one over Coleen with Cross of St George trousers'. Columnist Ian Gallagher concluded: 'Victoria (Beckham) is still Queen Bee. ... She ... was dazzling in an all-white outfit, St George Crosses decorating the pockets and jeans.'⁶⁹ Hegemonic masculinity is not only maintained by those occupying the position of power in the social hierarchy but also through the discursive practices and willing participation of those who are subordinated. Thus it seemed as though Victoria Beckham's choice of revealing outfits, which were no doubt carefully chosen, illustrate in a Gramscian sense how she was complicit with the mediated images and narratives that reinforced her subordinated 'emphasized femininity'.

'WAGS lift wives' world cup'

The 'infotainment' nature of the narratives about McLoughlin, Victoria Beckham and the other WAGS illustrated how their presence to support their men in Germany was used to provide light entertainment and amusement between matches. Typifying this approach, the WAGS' off-the-field exploits were humorously contrasted with their men's anaemic on-the-field performances. These narratives served to reinforce dominant notions about gendered identity as well as national identity, and even drew on an 'us vs them' discourse when comparing the English and German WAGS. Under the headline 'Our WAGS lift wives' World Cup: Frauleins look glum as England's girls show how to be real footballers' wives', author Richard Brooks noted: 'While David Beckham and his team have struggled for form on the pitch, their WAGS have displayed a world-beating talent for shopping, partying, and champagne quaffing.'⁷⁰ David Harrison's World Cup postscript summarized this: 'THEY SHOPPED by day and partied by night – and provided far more entertainment in Germany than the England football team.'⁷¹

Flying the flag

The English flag, the cross of St George, was strategically placed in the background of many carefully choreographed photographs appearing in the examined articles of English soccer players such as Rooney and David Beckham. The other main context in which the cross of St George was prominently featured was in the background of photographs of the WAGS and other bikini-clad young women doing their bit, by wearing the colours to 'support our boys', particularly in the popular newspapers examined, *The Sun* and the *Daily Mirror*. Typifying this type of image was a sexually suggestive posed photograph of McLoughlin under the headline 'Coleen flies flag on a jag'. Also the *Daily Mail* featured a photograph of two young women wearing cross of St George bikini tops above the headline 'UN-BRA-LIEVABLE! England fans celebrate as Sven's men hold on for a crucial win'.⁷² These young women seemed to epitomize Connell's notion of 'emphasized femininity' through the mediated portrayal of their compliant, sexualized role. In the newspapers' photographs, the WAGS hyper-feminine, 'hetero-sexy' appearance and subordinate role supporting the England team seemed to reaffirm the England players' hegemonic masculine status, and thus sustain the socially constructed gender hierarchy.⁷³ As Anderson noted, 'The epitome of this is when women cheer for male athletes relegating themselves to symbolic subservience'.⁷⁴

Postscript: Coleen McLoughlin empowered financially

Cashmore noted that in the era of celebrity culture we not only 'follow the exploits of irrelevant characters but also buy products they use and endorse'.⁷⁵ Reporter Ian Gallagher noted how several of the WAGS were able to leverage or translate their new-found celebrity status into book and magazine deals, as well as entrées into endorsement and modelling contracts. He quoted marketing expert Alex Hornshaw, of Get Me Media, in saying: 'They are tremendously appealing to advertisers because of their youth, glamour, and healthy appearance'.⁷⁶ In the aftermath of the World Cup, McLoughlin earned a lucrative £3 million modelling contract, as the face of the 'Must Have' George fashion collection for Asda. However, in response to the lacklustre performances of the England team and the lurid headlines about the WAGS' poor behaviour, the FA declared that the WAGS would not be accompanying players at future tournaments.

Conclusions

Gender identity, like other socially constructed identities (class, race, ethnic, and national), is not fixed but rather fluid and relational and as such is subject to change both historically and contextually.⁷⁷ Connell's relational theory of gender power relations notes that desirable notions of what construes masculinity in society are frequently contested and challenged.⁷⁸ However, in the socio-historical context of the 2006 World Cup, the gendered and national identity of the 'patriots at play', Rooney and David Beckham, generally (re)produced a symbolism that contrasted with the trivialization and sexualization of their partners, Coleen McLoughlin and Victoria Beckham. This suggests that although second-wave feminism may have influenced public thinking about gender power relations for over three decades, the traditional gender order as reflected in the English newspapers' narratives examined seemed resistant to change. Connell noted the role of conservative media

conglomerates, such as Rupert Murdoch's News Corporation, publishers of *The Times* and *The Sun* examined in this study, in upholding a traditional sex role gender ideology in which masculinity has traditionally been constructed in opposition to femininity.⁷⁹

The gendered narratives about England's mercurial young star player Wayne Rooney intersected with his northern working-class English national identity and his role as a 'patriot at play', which seemed designed to sustain particular definitions of conventional hypermasculinity. The way in which Rooney's performance of masculinity was portrayed resonated with the image that Proactive, his sports marketing agency firm, was trying to project for him. Proactive was trying to brand Rooney as 'the antithesis of David Beckham'. The brand values and image it was promoting for Rooney included 'playing up his working class street credentials ... as a product of the terraces'.⁸⁰ However, narratives about his youth and suspect temperament served to undermine his performance of hegemonic masculinity. It is noteworthy though that even after his sending off in the quarter-final against Portugal, Rooney was not vilified in the newspaper narratives in the same way as David Beckham was for a similar offence in the 1998 World Cup. This illustrates how narratives about masculine images that generally conform to hegemonic masculinity, like Rooney's, serve to reify the hierarchical gender order.

Although narratives about Victoria Beckham offered some resistance, generally the narratives about McLoughlin and the other WAGS who 'flew the flag for England' as unofficial cheerleaders, through their emphasized femininity, served almost as a foil to Rooney's and his teammates' roles as 'patriots at play' and their performance of hegemonic masculinity. The symbolism of the gendered division of labour in heterosexual relationships was upheld in the narratives, which reported the WAGS' subordinate role in supporting their men and looking after their families. McLoughlin was portrayed as having no conspicuous talent or accomplishment apart from being photogenic and romantically linked to a successful, popular male athlete. Moreover, the narratives about both McLoughlin and Victoria Beckham served to reinforce practices of cathexis that sustained hegemonic masculinity especially in the way they were sexualized.

In comparison the narratives about David Beckham and his celebrity wife also generally contained more fluid and contradictory discourses. The acceptance of David Beckham's more androgynous image conforms with Anderson's inclusive masculinities theory, which suggests that in the new millennium fluid masculine identities are becoming more accepted both within sport and mainstream culture.⁸¹ Moreover, the narratives about the strength and perceived dominance Victoria Beckham has within her superstar marriage and her influence in crafting her husband's performance of an inclusive masculinity for commercial gain also illustrates the fluidity and constant flux of hegemonic masculinity.⁸²

The contradictory masculine identity ascribed to David Beckham in the newspaper articles as well as in previous media studies suggests that a more heterofeminine masculinity has become at least somewhat socially acceptable even in a traditionally hegemonic masculine sphere such as international football.⁸³ Of course, Beckham's global marketing appeal, anchored in his accomplishments on the soccer field and his wholesome image, only enhance the acceptance of his inclusive masculinity. Beckham can behave in ways historically perceived as effeminate, while being unconcerned about perceptions of his heterosexuality and without 'fear of social stigma'.⁸⁴ Beckham's metrosexuality may transcend the traditional team sport

masculine culture for commercial appeal but his masculine transgressions do not threaten his status as 'a patriot at play' for England.

Inevitably in such relatively short careers, sport stars' athletic prowess eventually declines in the public glare and the same media that built them up then take their opportunity to knock them down in an almost formulaic fashion. An athlete's vulnerability is part of the appeal of voyeuristic mediated accounts and Beckham's decline as a player was the subject of much media narrative before, during and in the immediate aftermath of the 2006 World Cup.⁸⁵ However, Beckham's ambassadorial roles (e.g. the bids for the 2012 Olympic Games and World Cup 2018) reflect his enduring global appeal and suggest he may be able to overcome his declining football prowess. Celebrity culture is predicated on global consumption and commodification. Drawing from the work of Boorstin,⁸⁶ Cashmore noted, 'Where there were once 'colorful characters' or superstars, there are now iconic images created by corporate interests for the purpose of selling in a market that respects no national boundaries'.⁸⁷ Beckham is the epitome of a commodified sports celebrity or an object of consumption, whose 'name is often worth more than his services', although he still receives superstar treatment from media as evident by the mass of coverage – albeit much of it critical – of him by the English press for England's failure to win the 2006 World Cup.

Notes

1. Connell, *Gender and Power; The Men and the Boys; Masculinities*.
2. Tuck, 'Making Sense of Emerald Commotion'.
3. Maguire and Poulton, 'European Identity Politics in Euro 96'.
4. Horne, *Sport in Consumer Culture*.
5. Boyle, *Sports Journalism*.
6. Turner, *Understanding Celebrity*.
7. Duncan, 'Gender Warriors in Sport'; and Kian *et al.*, 'Masculine Hegemonic Hoops'.
8. Connell, *The Men and the Boys*.
9. Harris and Clayton, 'Femininity, Masculinity, Physicality'.
10. Duncan, 'Gender Warriors in Sport'; and Kian, 'A New Era for Women's Sports?'
11. Eastman and Billings, 'Sportscasting and Sports Reporting'; Vincent, 'Game, Sex, and Match'.
12. Connell, *Gender and Power*; Connell, *The Men and the Boys*; and Connell, *Masculinities*.
13. Ritchie, 'Sociological Theories of Sport'.
14. Connell, *Masculinities*.
15. Connell, *The Men and the Boys*.
16. *Ibid.*; and Connell, *Masculinities*.
17. Burstyn, *The Rites of Men*; Connell, *Gender and Power*.
18. Anderson, 'Orthodox & Inclusive Masculinity'; Connell, *The Men and the Boys*.
19. Connell and Messerschmidt, 'Hegemonic Masculinity'.
20. Connell, *Gender and Power*.
21. Vincent and Crossman, "'Alicia in Wonderland'".
22. McKee, 'A Beginner's Guide to Textual Analysis'.
23. *Daily Mirror*, 17 June 2006, 73.
24. Whannel, *Media Sport Stars*, 156.
25. *Daily Mail*, 11 June 2006, 12.
26. Messner, 'Masculinities and Athletic Careers'.
27. *Daily Mail*, Tuesday, June 12, 2006, 82.
28. Connell, *The Men and the Boys*.
29. Messner, 'Masculinities and Athletic Careers'.
30. *Daily Mail*, 20 June 2006, front page of sports section.

31. *Daily Mail*, 21 June 2006, 14.
32. Ibid.
33. Gill, 'Power and the Production of Subjects'.
34. Garland and Rowe, 'War Minus the Shooting?'
35. *Daily Mail*, 1 July 2006, front page.
36. *The Daily Telegraph*, 3 July 2006, S8.
37. Boyle, *Sport Journalism*.
38. Giardina, "'Bending It Like Beckham"'.
39. Vincent et al., 'The Multiple Brand Personalities of David Beckham'.
40. Whannel, *Media Sports Stars*.
41. Smart, *The Sport Star*.
42. *Daily Mirror*, 26 June 2006, 8.
43. *The Daily Telegraph*, 26 June 2006, S2.
44. Boorstin, *The Image*.
45. *Daily Mail*, 22 June 2006, 92.
46. Vincent et al., 'The Multiple Brand Personalities of David Beckham'.
47. *Daily Mail*, 21 June 2006, 85.
48. *The Sun*, 3 July 2006, 7.
49. Crolley and Hand, *Football and European Identity*.
50. *Sunday Telegraph*, 18 June 2006, S5.
51. Anderson, *Inclusive Masculinity*; Connell, *The Men and the Boys*.
52. *Daily Mail*, 3 July 2006, 75.
53. *The Daily Telegraph*, 3 July, 2006, S4.
54. Connell, *The Men and the Boys*, 201.
55. Ibid.
56. *Daily Mail*, 21 June 2006, 14.
57. Ibid., 12.
58. *The Mail on Sunday*, 25 June 2006, 31.
59. Boorstin, *The Image*.
60. *Daily Mail*, 10 June 2006, 2.
61. *Daily Mail*, 17 June 2006, 101.
62. Cashmore, *Celebrity/culture*.
63. Whannel, *Media Sports Stars*.
64. *Daily Mirror*, 16 June 2006, 3.
65. *The Times*, 26 June 2006, 15.
66. *Daily Mirror*, 24 June 2006, 6–7.
67. Vincent et al., 'The Multiple Brand Personalities of David Beckham'.
68. *Daily Mail*, 10 June 2006, 2.
69. *The Mail on Sunday*, 11 June 2006, 4.
70. *The Sunday Times*, 25 June 2006, 10.
71. *The Daily Telegraph*, 9 July 2006, 5.
72. *The Mail on Sunday*, 11 June 2006, 11.
73. Connell, *Gender and Power*.
74. Anderson, *Inclusive Masculinity*, 45.
75. Cashmore, *Celebrity/culture*, 185.
76. *Daily Mail*, 2 July 2006, 7.
77. Connell, *Masculinities*.
78. Connell and Messerschmidt, 'Hegemonic Masculinity'.
79. Connell, 'Change Among the Gatekeepers'.
80. *The Guardian*, 11 February 2010.
81. n.p. Anderson, *Inclusive Masculinity*.
82. Connell, *Masculinities*.
83. Harris and Clayton. 'Femininity, Masculinity, Physicality'.
84. Anderson, 'Inclusive Masculinity in a Fraternal Setting'.
85. Whannel, *Media Sports Stars*.
86. Boorstin, *The Image*.
87. Cashmore, *Celebrity/culture*, 244.

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Appendix: detailed methods

The newspapers

We examined all articles on or related to the World Cup published in the hard copies of *The Times*, *The Daily Telegraph*, *Daily Mail*, *Daily Mirror* and the *Sun*, as well as their respective Sunday editions and sister newspapers, which for the *Sun* is the *News of the World*. These newspapers were chosen because of their national prominence, extensive sports coverage, and because they represent different strands of the English newspaper market and therefore appeal to different demographic segments or readers. Data collection was from 8 June to 10 July 2006, which included the day prior to and the day after the tournament.

Coding procedures

The authors followed inductive coding practices that generated multiple levels of data, which were interpreted according to the larger theoretical frames of gender and national identity. Specifically, *open* and *axial* levels of coding comprised our textual analysis of the newspaper articles, which generated multiple and layered elements of analyses. Each article was read twice and narratives related to gender and national identity in articles devoted to the English national football team were initially highlighted. These themes were chronologically organized by person and newspaper. After constructing the initial database of transcripts, data were examined

multiple times with the aim of identifying dominant narratives as well as challenges and inconsistencies within the transcripts. Following the work of Creswell and Strauss and Corbin, this initial form of coding utilized a constant comparison means of analysis to generate emergent themes and locate systematic relationships within the data.¹ The constant comparative means of analysis was utilized in two levels of coding, *open* and *axial*.

Initially, *open coding* was utilized in an attempt to organize raw document data into overarching themes and thereby concentrate the large amounts of data into usable items for analysis. *Open coding* has been used successfully in the past to pull relevant themes to the surface buried deep inside the data. Such themes exist at a low level of abstraction and extend from the researchers' initial research question, concepts in the literature, terms used by members in the social setting or new thoughts stimulated by immersion in the data.² Attempting to more rigorously analyse our data, we built upon our *open coding* process and incorporated *axial coding* as a means of linking previously identified themes and categories within the data. *Axial coding* provides greater depth to initial thematic codes by connecting and relating codes to one another.³ Through *axial coding*, specific codes were developed across various articles and subsequently analyzed according to the larger theoretical frameworks of gender.

Analysis

Connell's theory of gender power relations⁴ was used as a basis for interpretation for the preliminary codes generated from this inductive process, which necessitated that certain themes relating to the gender discourses of the subjects in articles were given greater prominence. Thus, by design, this methodology does not aim to reproduce the newspapers' coverage or reporters' narratives, but to uncover the textual constructions of gender identity permeating the dominant discourses.

Validity/trustworthiness

Employing a methodology drawing upon multiple levels of coding and interpreting our data according to well-developed theoretical frameworks resulted in a reliable research design with validated analyses.⁵ Our analytical methods were designed to ensure consistent data collection and analysis, thus providing more validity to our findings. The end result was a dynamic and layered analytical framework that contributed to theoretical insights discussed below.

Limitations

While our coding process and data analysis offered insight into themes of gender identity, it is important to recognize that like all theoretical interpretations of social constructs ours is not without its own set of limitations. As Fairclough noted, 'we cannot assume that a text in its full actuality can be made transparent through applying the categories of a pre-existing analytical framework'.⁶ Thus we acknowledge that our use of existing theories to organize and orient our analysis potentially excludes alternative interpretations of our data. Further, our use of close textual analysis sought to explicate the development of gender identity on both local and global levels, managing these overlapping discourses through multiple levels of coding. As such, our analytical strategies assumed that close readings of public documents reveal larger cultural sensibilities and systems of meaning-making.

Notes to Appendix

- [1] Creswell, *Research Design*; Strauss and Corbin. *Basics of Qualitative Research*.
- [2] Neuman, *The Meanings of Methodology*.
- [3] Strauss and Corbin, *Basic of Qualitative Research*.
- [4] Connell, Gender and Power; Connell, *The Men and the Boys*; Connell, *Masculinities*.
- [5] Marshall and Rossman, *Designing Qualitative Research*.
- [6] Fairclough, *Analysing Discourse*, 16.